

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Aurangzeb: Religious Policy, North India & the Rajputs - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Aurangzeb: Religious Policy, North India & the Rajputs
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01 START WITH A DISCIPLINED QUESTION, NOT A VERDICT A defensible account begins neither with the verdict that personal	02 ORTHODOXY DID NOT ABOLISH TIMURID STATECRAFT A reliable sentence therefore says: the compilation made Hanafi legal
03 PERIODISE POLICY INSTEAD OF COLLECTING FOLKLORE Technically, Periodise policy instead of collecting folklore is analysed	04 JIZYAH IN 1679: A TAX WITH A MEANING LARGER THAN ITS LEDGER Personal orthodoxy and a wish to assert Islamic legitimacy are
05 TEMPLE POLICY MUST BE RECONSTRUCTED ONE ACTION AT A TIME A grant to a temple or Brahmin elsewhere is counter-evidence to a	06 COMPOSITE NOBILITY: PARTICIPATION WITHOUT A FALSE EQUALITY CLAIM Numbers without a year, denominator and category are worse than
07 THE 1675 EXECUTION: HISTORY, TRADITION AND CONSEQUENCE Names of companions and execution details should be used only if	08 NORTH INDIAN RESISTANCE: LOCAL POWER, AGRARIAN PRESSURE AND MOBILISATION The analytical comparison is useful precisely because it preserves
09 ALLIANCE WORKED THROUGH SERVICE, HONOUR AND CREDIBLE GUARANTEES Yet interpersonal trust was not enough: an alliance depends on clear	10 THE MARWAR CRISIS WAS A SUCCESSION FAILURE INTENSIFIED BY OCCUPATION Marwar was taken into khalisa while succession was disputed.
11 MEWAR'S ALLIANCE AND THE LIMITS OF DYNASTIC REBELLION Technically, Mewar's alliance and the limits of dynastic rebellion is	12 RECOGNITION IN 1698 DID NOT RESTORE THE OLD POLITICAL COMPACT Rajput distrust and jizyah-related alienation could raise the political
13 AKBAR AND AURANGZEB: COMPARISON WITHOUT MORALITY PLAY The interpretation that Aurangzeb was both a victim of circumstances	14 BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE The live page is a heritage and source-method bridge only.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Aurangzeb: Religious Policy, North India & the Rajputs - Complete Topic Package	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Learning MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x5)	3
Broad MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x11)	7
Remedial MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x4)	15
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	18
PART XIV - PYQ AUDIT, PRACTICE AND ANSWER WRITING	18
14. PYQ ownership audit and the discipline of original practice	18
PART XV - PYQ AUDIT AND ORIGINAL PRACTICE	22
Direct PYQ status and routing decision	22
PART XVI - EXAMINER-GRADE MAINS PRACTICE WITH SOLUTIONS	22
Mains 1 - 10 marks	22
Mains 2 - 15 marks	22
Mains 3 - 15 marks	23
Mains 4 - 10 marks	23
Mains 5 - 15 marks	23
Mains 6 - 15 marks	24
Mains 7 - 10 marks	24
Mains 8 - 20 marks	24
Mains 9 - 20 marks	25
Mains 10 - 20 marks	25
Final solved-answer self-audit	25

Aurangzeb: Religious Policy, North India & the Rajputs - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x5)

Original practice. Correct options rotate A -> B -> C -> D independently in this set; no item is presented as a verified CSE PYQ.

Learning MCQs 1

Which formulation best captures Aurangzeb's reign for historical analysis?

- A. Personal orthodoxy, legal idiom, sovereignty, politics and uneven administration interacted.
- B. Politics alone makes religious policy irrelevant.
- C. Religion alone explains every policy and rebellion.
- D. The ulama replaced the emperor as sovereign.

Answer: A. Explanation: It preserves both agency and institution; the closest distractor, 'politics alone', wrongly removes the documented legal-symbolic dimension.

Learning MCQs 2

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Ajit Singh - recognition in 1679.
- B. Aurangzeb - reign from 1658 to 1707.
- C. Jai Singh - death in 1658.
- D. Jaswant Singh - death in 1667.

Answer: B. Explanation: 1658-1707 is the secure reign span; the closest distractor reverses the dated roles of Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh.

Learning MCQs 3

Why is the Fatawa-i-Alamgiri not safely described as a modern constitution?

- A. It abolished imperial regulations.
- B. It was written after Aurangzeb's death.
- C. It was a collective Hanafi legal compendium whose uniform enforcement cannot be presumed.
- D. It was a village revenue register.

Answer: C. Explanation: The discriminator is compendium versus statute; the 'abolished regulations' option ignores zawabit and imperial discretion.

Learning MCQs 4

What does zawabit most usefully indicate in this context?

- A. A hereditary Rajput homeland.
- B. A jizyah collection category.
- C. A Sikh initiation rite.
- D. Ruler-made administrative regulations alongside legal idiom.

Answer: D. Explanation: Zawabit concerns imperial regulation; the closest distractor confuses it with watan, a distinct Rajput political vocabulary.

Learning MCQs 5

Which inference is safest about court puritan measures?

- A. A court-centred measure needs separate evidence before being made an empire-wide social claim.
- B. All reports are mere folklore.

- C. Every reported measure was uniformly enforced.
- D. No symbolic measure had political meaning.

Answer: A. Explanation: Scale is the discriminator: court action can matter without proving universal compliance; 'no meaning' is the opposite overcorrection.

Learning MCQs 6

Jizyah should be distinguished most directly from:

- A. A policy with symbolic effects.
- B. Land revenue and customs duties.
- C. A poll tax in legal-political idiom.
- D. A measure reimposed in 1679.

Answer: B. Explanation: Jizyah is not kharaj/land revenue or customs; the closest distractor states a true but non-distinguishing feature.

Learning MCQs 7

Which is a defensible account of motives for jizyah in 1679?

- A. Only private piety explains it.
- B. Only a proven revenue crisis explains it.
- C. Orthodoxy, legitimacy, political signalling and fiscal context can be weighed without assigning one exclusive motive.
- D. It had no political meaning because collection varied.

Answer: C. Explanation: The correct answer keeps motive plural and qualified; 'only private piety' mistakes one relevant factor for a complete proof.

Learning MCQs 8

What is the safest conclusion about jizyah's effects?

- A. It instantly ended Hindu elite service.
- B. It uniformly reached every non-Muslim subject.
- C. It solved the empire's fiscal problems.
- D. Its uneven collection did not prevent a substantial symbolic and alienating effect.

Answer: D. Explanation: Uneven implementation is not political insignificance; the closest distractor overstates universal collection.

Learning MCQs 9

Which distinction is essential in temple-policy analysis?

- A. Demolition, conversion, confiscation, restriction and grant are separate actions.
- B. Every temple case proves a universal order.
- C. A court text proves identical village practice.
- D. A grant proves no destruction elsewhere.

Answer: A. Explanation: Action taxonomy is the discriminator; the closest distractor wrongly lets one type of evidence settle the whole empire.

Learning MCQs 10

How should the 1669 temple/schools order be used?

- A. As an undated universal destruction order.
- B. As a chronicle-context claim whose wording, cases and follow-through must be assessed.
- C. As a modern court finding.
- D. As proof no old temple was ever harmed.

Answer: B. Explanation: Chronicle genre and precise reach matter; the universal-order option converts a difficult text into a claim it cannot bear alone.

Learning MCQs 11

What does a documented temple grant most directly establish?

- A. That no punitive temple action occurred elsewhere.
- B. That all temples were legally equal.
- C. A particular transaction or protection in its stated context.
- D. That court chronicles are useless.

Answer: C. Explanation: Case-specific reach is the discriminator; the closest distractor mistakes counter-evidence to a universal claim for total exoneration.

Learning MCQs 12

Which statement best handles Hindu participation in Mughal service?

- A. It proves all religious differentiation disappeared.
- B. It proves no Rajput resisted.
- C. It makes jizyah economically impossible.
- D. Continued service shows elite incorporation but does not demonstrate mass religious equality.

Answer: D. Explanation: Inclusion and equality are different questions; the closest distractor converts an elite pattern into a total social conclusion.

Learning MCQs 13

Why are precise late-reign nobility percentages risky without a citation?

- A. A percentage needs a date, denominator and defined category.
- B. Recruitment ended after 1679.
- C. Only Rajputs could hold mansabs.
- D. Percentages are never useful in history.

Answer: A. Explanation: Quantification is valid only when specified; the closest distractor falsely claims recruitment stopped.

Learning MCQs 14

What is the most evidence-sensitive account of Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution?

- A. It had no religious consequence.
- B. Imperial law-and-order framing and Sikh martyr-memory accounts must both be located and assessed.
- C. One source can settle every motive beyond dispute.
- D. It alone mechanically created the Khalsa.

Answer: B. Explanation: The key is source reach and consequence; the closest distractor mistakes a profound antecedent for a sole cause of 1699.

Learning MCQs 15

Which date pair is correctly matched?

- A. Satnami revolt - 1669; Khalsa - 1681.
- B. Jaswant Singh's death - 1699; Khalsa - 1707.
- C. Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution - 1675; Khalsa - 1699.
- D. Jizyah - 1675; Khalsa - 1679.

Answer: C. Explanation: 1675 and 1699 are the secure anchors; the closest distractor interchanges the jizyah and execution dates.

Learning MCQs 16

Why should the Khalsa not be explained by one event alone?

- A. Only hill chiefs caused Sikh change.
- B. The 1675 execution had no importance.
- C. The Khalsa had no relation to earlier Sikh history.
- D. Organisation, leadership, memory and local political conflict also shaped Sikh militarisation.

Answer: D. Explanation: Multi-causality is the discriminator; the closest distractor denies the execution's consequence rather than resisting monocausality.

Learning MCQs 17

What is the strongest frame for Gokula's Jat uprising?

- A. Local power, agrarian pressure, official coercion and community mobilisation interacted.
- B. It was already the Bharatpur state.
- C. It was a coordinated all-India rebellion.
- D. A single temple issue fully explains it.

Answer: A. Explanation: The correct answer preserves the Mathura-region complexity; the closest distractor converts later political formation into an immediate outcome.

Learning MCQs 18

What does the Satnami revolt of 1672 most clearly illustrate?

- A. All local rebellions shared one programme.
- B. A local confrontation could escalate through sect/community mobilisation and be rapidly suppressed.
- C. Satnamis controlled Mewar.
- D. The Mughal Empire had already collapsed.

Answer: B. Explanation: Rapid suppression and escalation belong together; the closest distractor mistakes a local rising for proof of total collapse.

Learning MCQs 19

Which proposition about Rajput policy before 1678 is best supported?

- A. He planned Rajput destruction from accession.
- B. The Marwar crisis began with Akbar's revolt.
- C. Aurangzeb initially used and valued leading Rajput service, including Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh.
- D. All Rajputs were excluded from mansabs.

Answer: C. Explanation: Early partnership is the key chronological control; the closest distractor reverses the later 1681 revolt and 1678 succession crisis.

Learning MCQs 20

What did watan mean most centrally in the Marwar conflict?

- A. An imperial legal compendium.
- B. A Deccan military grant.
- C. A temporary jizyah exemption.
- D. Hereditary homeland and authority whose recognition affected honour and service.

Answer: D. Explanation: Watan denotes hereditary territorial-political stake; the closest distractor confuses it with jagir-like revenue assignment.

Broad MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x11)

Original practice. Correct options rotate A -> B -> C -> D independently in this set; no item is presented as a verified CSE PYQ.

Broad MCQs 1

Which formulation about Jaswant Singh's death is accurate?

- A. He died at Jamrud in 1678 without a surviving male heir at that moment; posthumous claims followed.
- B. He was killed in the 1681 revolt.
- C. He died in Jodhpur after Ajit's recognition.
- D. He died childless in 1679 and left no claimant.

Answer: A. Explanation: The qualification about posthumous claimants prevents the misleading 'childless' shorthand; the closest distractor erases Ajit's legitimacy.

Broad MCQs 2

What did taking Marwar into khalisa automatically mean?

- A. It legally ended all Rathor hereditary claims.
- B. It meant crown-revenue administration, not automatically permanent annexation.
- C. It made Inder Singh emperor.
- D. It abolished Rajput service elsewhere.

Answer: B. Explanation: Khalisa is an administrative category; the closest distractor mistakes temporary imperial control for a final political verdict.

Broad MCQs 3

Why are Waqa-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahi valuable?

- A. They replace all court chronicles.
- B. They prove every later bardic episode literally.
- C. They add local detail on succession, debt and administrative context.
- D. They are neutral complete archives of all India.

Answer: C. Explanation: Their local specificity is the strength and limit; the closest distractor turns a valuable source into a total archive.

Broad MCQs 4

What is the secure core of Durgadas's role?

- A. Every escape-story detail is independently verified.
- B. He permanently expelled the Mughals in 1679.
- C. He led the Satnami revolt.
- D. He became central to Rathor resistance and protection of Ajit's claim.

Answer: D. Explanation: The stable political role matters more than embellishment; the closest distractor treats varying rescue narratives as uniformly proven.

Broad MCQs 5

Which factor did NOT by itself explain failure of compromise in Marwar?

- A. A single, uncomplicated religious motive.
- B. Factional and centralising pressures.
- C. Honour and distrust over custody.
- D. Occupation and official conduct.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Marwar crisis is multi-causal; the closest distractor ignores succession and watan politics.

Broad MCQs 6

Why did Mewar support Marwar?

- A. All Mewar elites joined Prince Akbar in 1678.
- B. Kinship, concern about imperial interference, security and Rajput autonomy mattered alongside jizyah's signal.
- C. Jizyah alone mechanically determined the decision.
- D. Mewar had no interest in Marwar's succession.

Answer: B. Explanation: The correct answer has multiple motives; the closest distractor reduces a political decision to one tax.

Broad MCQs 7

What terrain lesson follows from the Mewar war?

- A. Mewar lay on the Bengal delta.
- B. Rajput warfare had no logistical dimension.
- C. Aravalli hill conditions increased the value of mobility, passes and local knowledge.
- D. Terrain made all Mughal occupation impossible.

Answer: C. Explanation: Terrain shapes rather than predetermines outcomes; the closest distractor turns a strategic advantage into impossibility.

Broad MCQs 8

How should the forged-letter episode in Prince Akbar's revolt be presented?

- A. As a jizyah regulation.
- B. As an event before Jaswant's death.
- C. As conclusive proof of every Rajput motive.
- D. As a provenance-sensitive account, not an independently settled explanatory fact.

Answer: D. Explanation: The relevant discriminator is source status; the closest distractor asks the episode to carry far more causal weight than its provenance permits.

Broad MCQs 9

Which outcome of the 1681 revolt is accurate?

- A. The dynastic challenge failed, but it did not restore trust or end Rajput resistance.
- B. All Rajput houses left Mughal service.
- C. Ajit was fully restored in 1681.
- D. Prince Akbar immediately became emperor.

Answer: A. Explanation: Failure of a revolt is not repair of a political breach; the closest distractor confuses later 1698 recognition with 1681.

Broad MCQs 10

What is the safest account of Ajit's 1698 recognition?

- A. It fully restored the pre-1678 compact.
- B. It was a limited settlement; Mughal control over Jodhpur remained an issue.
- C. It permanently ended all conflict by 1698.
- D. It preceded Jaswant Singh's death.

Answer: B. Explanation: Recognition with limits is the key; the closest distractor converts a compromise into complete restoration.

Broad MCQs 11

Why does continued Hada/Kachhwaha service matter?

- A. It makes all temple evidence false.
- B. It makes jizyah a land tax.

- C. It shows differentiated Rajput politics rather than universal secession.
- D. It proves Marwar-Mewar suffered no political cost.

Answer: C. Explanation: Continued service qualifies a universal claim; the closest distractor wrongly uses it to erase the serious breach.

Broad MCQs 12

What is meant by the political cost exceeding immediate military cost?

- A. The Rajputs defeated every Mughal army.
- B. No military resources were used.
- C. The empire fell immediately in 1681.
- D. Prestige and confidence in Mughal guarantees could be damaged even when later fighting used limited forces.

Answer: D. Explanation: Legitimacy can have strategic value; the closest distractor turns a qualified cost argument into an impossible absolute.

Broad MCQs 13

How should Topic 22 connect to the Deccan?

- A. As a bounded timing and cooperation problem; Topic 23 owns the full Deccan narrative.
- B. By inventing precise Rajasthan-to-Deccan budgets.
- C. By ignoring the Deccan after 1681.
- D. By explaining every Rajput event as a Maratha event.

Answer: A. Explanation: The bridge is political-resource interaction; the closest distractor supplies unsupported budgets.

Broad MCQs 14

Which comparison of Akbar and Aurangzeb is most defensible?

- A. Akbar never used force.
- B. Compare inclusive idiom, fiscal differentiation, elite bargains and political contexts, not moral caricatures.
- C. Aurangzeb never recruited Hindus.
- D. Their policies were identical in every respect.

Answer: B. Explanation: A common yardstick is needed; the closest distractor makes an absolute claim contradicted by continued composite service.

Broad MCQs 15

What does 'victim and maker of circumstances' invite?

- A. Excuse every decision as inevitable.
- B. Treat personality as the sole cause.
- C. Weigh inherited constraints with Aurangzeb's own policy choices.
- D. Avoid evidence because motives are complex.

Answer: C. Explanation: Structure and agency must be jointly analysed; the closest distractor turns context into exoneration.

Broad MCQs 16

Which source has the strongest direct reach for a particular grant?

- A. A later undated internet list.
- B. A general modern polemic.
- C. An unrelated traveller's anecdote.
- D. The dated farman or record of that grant.

Answer: D. Explanation: Specificity and provenance matter; the closest distractor replaces a case record with a general claim.

Broad MCQs 17

What can a court chronicle most reliably contribute?

- A. Official chronology and ideology, with attention to selection and silence.
- B. A guarantee of uniform implementation.
- C. An automatically neutral local record.
- D. A complete social census.

Answer: A. Explanation: Genre is the discriminator; the closest distractor overextends official narrative into a social census.

Broad MCQs 18

Why is modern litigation not proof of a medieval event?

- A. A claim needs no medieval provenance.
- B. Pleadings and modern adjudication answer present legal questions, not automatically historical proof.
- C. Courts can never examine archives.
- D. All historical sources are equally weak.

Answer: B. Explanation: The boundary is evidentiary reach; the closest distractor mistakes a current claim for a dated historical source.

Broad MCQs 19

What is the final causal verdict on religious policy and decline?

- A. It produced immediate empire-wide collapse in 1679.
- B. It explains every Deccan outcome.
- C. It was contributory to weakened legitimacy, not a monocausal explanation of decline.
- D. It had no political effect.

Answer: C. Explanation: A contributory mechanism fits the evidence; the closest distractor asserts immediate collapse despite continued imperial capacity.

Broad MCQs 20

Which formulation best captures Aurangzeb's reign for historical analysis?

- A. The ulama replaced the emperor as sovereign.
- B. Religion alone explains every policy and rebellion.
- C. Politics alone makes religious policy irrelevant.
- D. Personal orthodoxy, legal idiom, sovereignty, politics and uneven administration interacted.

Answer: D. Explanation: It preserves both agency and institution; the closest distractor, 'politics alone', wrongly removes the documented legal-symbolic dimension.

Broad MCQs 21

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Aurangzeb - reign from 1658 to 1707.
- B. Ajit Singh - recognition in 1679.
- C. Jaswant Singh - death in 1667.
- D. Jai Singh - death in 1658.

Answer: A. Explanation: 1658-1707 is the secure reign span; the closest distractor reverses the dated roles of Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh.

Broad MCQs 22

Why is the Fatawa-i-Alamgiri not safely described as a modern constitution?

- A. It was a village revenue register.
- B. It was a collective Hanafi legal compendium whose uniform enforcement cannot be presumed.

- C. It abolished imperial regulations.
- D. It was written after Aurangzeb's death.

Answer: B. Explanation: The discriminator is compendium versus statute; the 'abolished regulations' option ignores zawabit and imperial discretion.

Broad MCQs 23

What does zawabit most usefully indicate in this context?

- A. A hereditary Rajput homeland.
- B. A Sikh initiation rite.
- C. Ruler-made administrative regulations alongside legal idiom.
- D. A jizyah collection category.

Answer: C. Explanation: Zawabit concerns imperial regulation; the closest distractor confuses it with watan, a distinct Rajput political vocabulary.

Broad MCQs 24

Which inference is safest about court puritan measures?

- A. No symbolic measure had political meaning.
- B. Every reported measure was uniformly enforced.
- C. All reports are mere folklore.
- D. A court-centred measure needs separate evidence before being made an empire-wide social claim.

Answer: D. Explanation: Scale is the discriminator: court action can matter without proving universal compliance; 'no meaning' is the opposite overcorrection.

Broad MCQs 25

Jizyah should be distinguished most directly from:

- A. Land revenue and customs duties.
- B. A policy with symbolic effects.
- C. A measure reimposed in 1679.
- D. A poll tax in legal-political idiom.

Answer: A. Explanation: Jizyah is not kharaj/land revenue or customs; the closest distractor states a true but non-distinguishing feature.

Broad MCQs 26

Which is a defensible account of motives for jizyah in 1679?

- A. It had no political meaning because collection varied.
- B. Orthodoxy, legitimacy, political signalling and fiscal context can be weighed without assigning one exclusive motive.
- C. Only a proven revenue crisis explains it.
- D. Only private piety explains it.

Answer: B. Explanation: The correct answer keeps motive plural and qualified; 'only private piety' mistakes one relevant factor for a complete proof.

Broad MCQs 27

What is the safest conclusion about jizyah's effects?

- A. It solved the empire's fiscal problems.
- B. It uniformly reached every non-Muslim subject.
- C. Its uneven collection did not prevent a substantial symbolic and alienating effect.
- D. It instantly ended Hindu elite service.

Answer: C. Explanation: Uneven implementation is not political insignificance; the closest distractor overstates universal collection.

Broad MCQs 28

Which distinction is essential in temple-policy analysis?

- A. Every temple case proves a universal order.
- B. A court text proves identical village practice.
- C. A grant proves no destruction elsewhere.
- D. Demolition, conversion, confiscation, restriction and grant are separate actions.

Answer: D. Explanation: Action taxonomy is the discriminator; the closest distractor wrongly lets one type of evidence settle the whole empire.

Broad MCQs 29

How should the 1669 temple/schools order be used?

- A. As a chronicle-context claim whose wording, cases and follow-through must be assessed.
- B. As an undated universal destruction order.
- C. As a modern court finding.
- D. As proof no old temple was ever harmed.

Answer: A. Explanation: Chronicle genre and precise reach matter; the universal-order option converts a difficult text into a claim it cannot bear alone.

Broad MCQs 30

What does a documented temple grant most directly establish?

- A. That no punitive temple action occurred elsewhere.
- B. A particular transaction or protection in its stated context.
- C. That all temples were legally equal.
- D. That court chronicles are useless.

Answer: B. Explanation: Case-specific reach is the discriminator; the closest distractor mistakes counter-evidence to a universal claim for total exoneration.

Broad MCQs 31

Which statement best handles Hindu participation in Mughal service?

- A. It proves all religious differentiation disappeared.
- B. It proves no Rajput resisted.
- C. Continued service shows elite incorporation but does not demonstrate mass religious equality.
- D. It makes jizyah economically impossible.

Answer: C. Explanation: Inclusion and equality are different questions; the closest distractor converts an elite pattern into a total social conclusion.

Broad MCQs 32

Why are precise late-reign nobility percentages risky without a citation?

- A. Only Rajputs could hold mansabs.
- B. Recruitment ended after 1679.
- C. Percentages are never useful in history.
- D. A percentage needs a date, denominator and defined category.

Answer: D. Explanation: Quantification is valid only when specified; the closest distractor falsely claims recruitment stopped.

Broad MCQs 33

What is the most evidence-sensitive account of Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution?

- A. Imperial law-and-order framing and Sikh martyr-memory accounts must both be located and assessed.
- B. One source can settle every motive beyond dispute.
- C. It had no religious consequence.
- D. It alone mechanically created the Khalsa.

Answer: A. Explanation: The key is source reach and consequence; the closest distractor mistakes a profound antecedent for a sole cause of 1699.

Broad MCQs 34

Which date pair is correctly matched?

- A. Jaswant Singh's death - 1699; Khalsa - 1707.
- B. Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution - 1675; Khalsa - 1699.
- C. Jizyah - 1675; Khalsa - 1679.
- D. Satnami revolt - 1669; Khalsa - 1681.

Answer: B. Explanation: 1675 and 1699 are the secure anchors; the closest distractor interchanges the jizyah and execution dates.

Broad MCQs 35

Why should the Khalsa not be explained by one event alone?

- A. The Khalsa had no relation to earlier Sikh history.
- B. Only hill chiefs caused Sikh change.
- C. Organisation, leadership, memory and local political conflict also shaped Sikh militarisation.
- D. The 1675 execution had no importance.

Answer: C. Explanation: Multi-causality is the discriminator; the closest distractor denies the execution's consequence rather than resisting monocausality.

Broad MCQs 36

What is the strongest frame for Gokula's Jat uprising?

- A. It was already the Bharatpur state.
- B. It was a coordinated all-India rebellion.
- C. A single temple issue fully explains it.
- D. Local power, agrarian pressure, official coercion and community mobilisation interacted.

Answer: D. Explanation: The correct answer preserves the Mathura-region complexity; the closest distractor converts later political formation into an immediate outcome.

Broad MCQs 37

What does the Satnami revolt of 1672 most clearly illustrate?

- A. A local confrontation could escalate through sect/community mobilisation and be rapidly suppressed.
- B. The Mughal Empire had already collapsed.
- C. All local rebellions shared one programme.
- D. Satnamis controlled Mewar.

Answer: A. Explanation: Rapid suppression and escalation belong together; the closest distractor mistakes a local rising for proof of total collapse.

Broad MCQs 38

Which proposition about Rajput policy before 1678 is best supported?

- A. The Marwar crisis began with Akbar's revolt.
- B. Aurangzeb initially used and valued leading Rajput service, including Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh.
- C. All Rajputs were excluded from mansabs.
- D. He planned Rajput destruction from accession.

Answer: B. Explanation: Early partnership is the key chronological control; the closest distractor reverses the later 1681 revolt and 1678 succession crisis.

Broad MCQs 39

What did watan mean most centrally in the Marwar conflict?

- A. A Deccan military grant.
- B. An imperial legal compendium.
- C. Hereditary homeland and authority whose recognition affected honour and service.
- D. A temporary jizyah exemption.

Answer: C. Explanation: Watan denotes hereditary territorial-political stake; the closest distractor confuses it with jagir-like revenue assignment.

Broad MCQs 40

Which formulation about Jaswant Singh's death is accurate?

- A. He died in Jodhpur after Ajit's recognition.
- B. He was killed in the 1681 revolt.
- C. He died childless in 1679 and left no claimant.
- D. He died at Jamrud in 1678 without a surviving male heir at that moment; posthumous claims followed.

Answer: D. Explanation: The qualification about posthumous claimants prevents the misleading 'childless' shorthand; the closest distractor erases Ajit's legitimacy.

Broad MCQs 41

What did taking Marwar into khalisa automatically mean?

- A. It meant crown-revenue administration, not automatically permanent annexation.
- B. It made Inder Singh emperor.
- C. It abolished Rajput service elsewhere.
- D. It legally ended all Rathor hereditary claims.

Answer: A. Explanation: Khalisa is an administrative category; the closest distractor mistakes temporary imperial control for a final political verdict.

Broad MCQs 42

Why are Waqa-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahi valuable?

- A. They prove every later bardic episode literally.
- B. They add local detail on succession, debt and administrative context.
- C. They are neutral complete archives of all India.
- D. They replace all court chronicles.

Answer: B. Explanation: Their local specificity is the strength and limit; the closest distractor turns a valuable source into a total archive.

Broad MCQs 43

What is the secure core of Durgadas's role?

- A. Every escape-story detail is independently verified.
- B. He led the Satnami revolt.
- C. He became central to Rathor resistance and protection of Ajit's claim.
- D. He permanently expelled the Mughals in 1679.

Answer: C. Explanation: The stable political role matters more than embellishment; the closest distractor treats varying rescue narratives as uniformly proven.

Broad MCQs 44

Which factor did NOT by itself explain failure of compromise in Marwar?

- A. Honour and distrust over custody.
- B. Occupation and official conduct.
- C. Factional and centralising pressures.
- D. A single, uncomplicated religious motive.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Marwar crisis is multi-causal; the closest distractor ignores succession and watan politics.

Remedial MCQs - original (correct options A-B-C-D x4)

Original practice. Correct options rotate A -> B -> C -> D independently in this set; no item is presented as a verified CSE PYQ.

Remedial MCQs 1

Which inference is safest about court puritan measures?

- A. A court-centred measure needs separate evidence before being made an empire-wide social claim.
- B. No symbolic measure had political meaning.
- C. All reports are mere folklore.
- D. Every reported measure was uniformly enforced.

Answer: A. Explanation: Scale is the discriminator: court action can matter without proving universal compliance; 'no meaning' is the opposite overcorrection.

Remedial MCQs 2

Jizyah should be distinguished most directly from:

- A. A poll tax in legal-political idiom.
- B. Land revenue and customs duties.
- C. A measure reimposed in 1679.
- D. A policy with symbolic effects.

Answer: B. Explanation: Jizyah is not kharaj/land revenue or customs; the closest distractor states a true but non-distinguishing feature.

Remedial MCQs 3

Which is a defensible account of motives for jizyah in 1679?

- A. It had no political meaning because collection varied.
- B. Only private piety explains it.
- C. Orthodoxy, legitimacy, political signalling and fiscal context can be weighed without assigning one exclusive motive.
- D. Only a proven revenue crisis explains it.

Answer: C. Explanation: The correct answer keeps motive plural and qualified; 'only private piety' mistakes one relevant factor for a complete proof.

Remedial MCQs 4

What is the safest conclusion about jizyah's effects?

- A. It solved the empire's fiscal problems.
- B. It instantly ended Hindu elite service.
- C. It uniformly reached every non-Muslim subject.
- D. Its uneven collection did not prevent a substantial symbolic and alienating effect.

Answer: D. Explanation: Uneven implementation is not political insignificance; the closest distractor overstates universal collection.

Remedial MCQs 5

Which distinction is essential in temple-policy analysis?

- A. Demolition, conversion, confiscation, restriction and grant are separate actions.
- B. A court text proves identical village practice.
- C. A grant proves no destruction elsewhere.
- D. Every temple case proves a universal order.

Answer: A. Explanation: Action taxonomy is the discriminator; the closest distractor wrongly lets one type of evidence settle the whole empire.

Remedial MCQs 6

How should the 1669 temple/schools order be used?

- A. As an undated universal destruction order.
- B. As a chronicle-context claim whose wording, cases and follow-through must be assessed.
- C. As proof no old temple was ever harmed.
- D. As a modern court finding.

Answer: B. Explanation: Chronicle genre and precise reach matter; the universal-order option converts a difficult text into a claim it cannot bear alone.

Remedial MCQs 7

What does a documented temple grant most directly establish?

- A. That all temples were legally equal.
- B. That court chronicles are useless.
- C. A particular transaction or protection in its stated context.
- D. That no punitive temple action occurred elsewhere.

Answer: C. Explanation: Case-specific reach is the discriminator; the closest distractor mistakes counter-evidence to a universal claim for total exoneration.

Remedial MCQs 8

Which statement best handles Hindu participation in Mughal service?

- A. It proves all religious differentiation disappeared.
- B. It proves no Rajput resisted.
- C. It makes jizyah economically impossible.
- D. Continued service shows elite incorporation but does not demonstrate mass religious equality.

Answer: D. Explanation: Inclusion and equality are different questions; the closest distractor converts an elite pattern into a total social conclusion.

Remedial MCQs 9

Why are precise late-reign nobility percentages risky without a citation?

- A. A percentage needs a date, denominator and defined category.
- B. Percentages are never useful in history.
- C. Only Rajputs could hold mansabs.
- D. Recruitment ended after 1679.

Answer: A. Explanation: Quantification is valid only when specified; the closest distractor falsely claims recruitment stopped.

Remedial MCQs 10

What is the most evidence-sensitive account of Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution?

- A. It alone mechanically created the Khalsa.
- B. Imperial law-and-order framing and Sikh martyr-memory accounts must both be located and assessed.
- C. One source can settle every motive beyond dispute.
- D. It had no religious consequence.

Answer: B. Explanation: The key is source reach and consequence; the closest distractor mistakes a profound antecedent for a sole cause of 1699.

Remedial MCQs 11

Which date pair is correctly matched?

- A. Jizyah - 1675; Khalsa - 1679.
- B. Satnami revolt - 1669; Khalsa - 1681.
- C. Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution - 1675; Khalsa - 1699.
- D. Jaswant Singh's death - 1699; Khalsa - 1707.

Answer: C. Explanation: 1675 and 1699 are the secure anchors; the closest distractor interchanges the jizyah and execution dates.

Remedial MCQs 12

Why should the Khalsa not be explained by one event alone?

- A. The Khalsa had no relation to earlier Sikh history.
- B. Only hill chiefs caused Sikh change.
- C. The 1675 execution had no importance.
- D. Organisation, leadership, memory and local political conflict also shaped Sikh militarisation.

Answer: D. Explanation: Multi-causality is the discriminator; the closest distractor denies the execution's consequence rather than resisting monocausality.

Remedial MCQs 13

What is the strongest frame for Gokula's Jat uprising?

- A. Local power, agrarian pressure, official coercion and community mobilisation interacted.
- B. A single temple issue fully explains it.
- C. It was already the Bharatpur state.
- D. It was a coordinated all-India rebellion.

Answer: A. Explanation: The correct answer preserves the Mathura-region complexity; the closest distractor converts later political formation into an immediate outcome.

Remedial MCQs 14

What does the Satnami revolt of 1672 most clearly illustrate?

- A. All local rebellions shared one programme.
- B. A local confrontation could escalate through sect/community mobilisation and be rapidly suppressed.
- C. Satnamis controlled Mewar.
- D. The Mughal Empire had already collapsed.

Answer: B. Explanation: Rapid suppression and escalation belong together; the closest distractor mistakes a local rising for proof of total collapse.

Remedial MCQs 15

Which proposition about Rajput policy before 1678 is best supported?

- A. He planned Rajput destruction from accession.
- B. The Marwar crisis began with Akbar's revolt.
- C. Aurangzeb initially used and valued leading Rajput service, including Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh.
- D. All Rajputs were excluded from mansabs.

Answer: C. Explanation: Early partnership is the key chronological control; the closest distractor reverses the later 1681 revolt and 1678 succession crisis.

Remedial MCQs 16

What did watan mean most centrally in the Marwar conflict?

- A. A Deccan military grant.
- B. A temporary jizyah exemption.
- C. An imperial legal compendium.
- D. Hereditary homeland and authority whose recognition affected honour and service.

Answer: D. Explanation: Watan denotes hereditary territorial-political stake; the closest distractor confuses it with jagir-like revenue assignment.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART XIV - PYQ AUDIT, PRACTICE AND ANSWER WRITING

14. PYQ ownership audit and the discipline of original practice

A search of the local official/OCR 2018-2025 CSE Prelims and GS-I material, together with available routing material, found no exact direct CSE question owned by this Topic 22 cluster on Aurangzeb's religious policy, jizyah, temple cases, Guru Tegh Bahadur, Jats, Satnamis, Marwar-Mewar, Durgadas, Prince Akbar or Rajput relations. An OCR hit containing Aurangzeb was an adjacent ruler-identification option, not a Topic 22 question. Generic Sikh, Bhakti, Maratha/Deccan or art questions are not misrouted here. Therefore this workbook does not pretend that an original question is a verified PYQ.

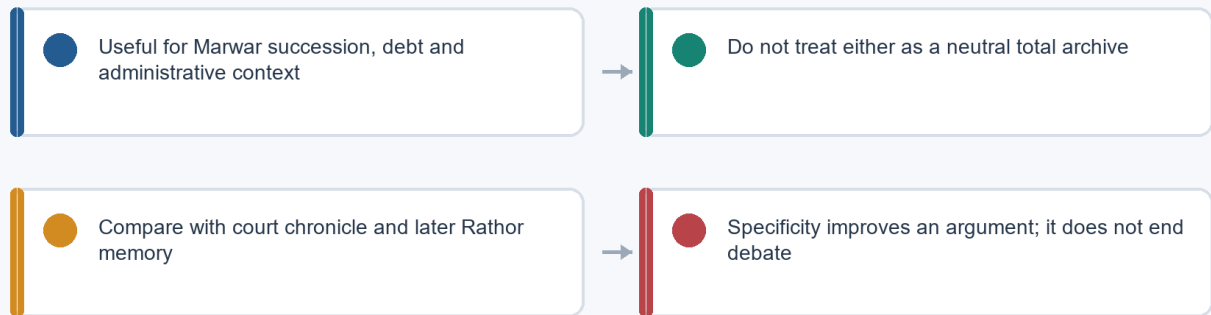
The honest direct-PYQ status is a gap, not an invitation to manufacture wording or answer keys. Useful adjacent material can be flagged only when its full wording and source are available. No official key is claimed where no relevant official question exists. The practice below is original and tests distinctions the topic makes examinable: scale of evidence, jizyah versus land revenue, law versus enforcement, inclusion versus equality, succession versus annexation, and religious meaning versus one-cause explanation.

For Mains, directive fidelity matters more than a memorised list. "Assess" calls for a weighed verdict; "examine" asks for mechanism and qualification; "compare" requires an explicit common yardstick; "discuss" requires scope rather than a one-sided prosecution or defence. The reusable answer spine is claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification. A map or small matrix improves an answer only if it clarifies chronology, terrain or competing explanation.

The current-affairs audit is deliberately restrained. Official heritage, archive and court-source searches for the six months preceding 18 August 2026 did not yield a material safe official anchor specific to this historical topic. No pending litigation or political claim is used as medieval proof. The correct session statement is: "No material recent official current-affairs anchor suitable for historical use was found; static relevance retained."

EXAM CAUTION: Keep the scale of a claim equal to the scale of its evidence. A court chronicle, local record, grant, tradition and modern allegation do not have identical reach.

Waqā-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahī

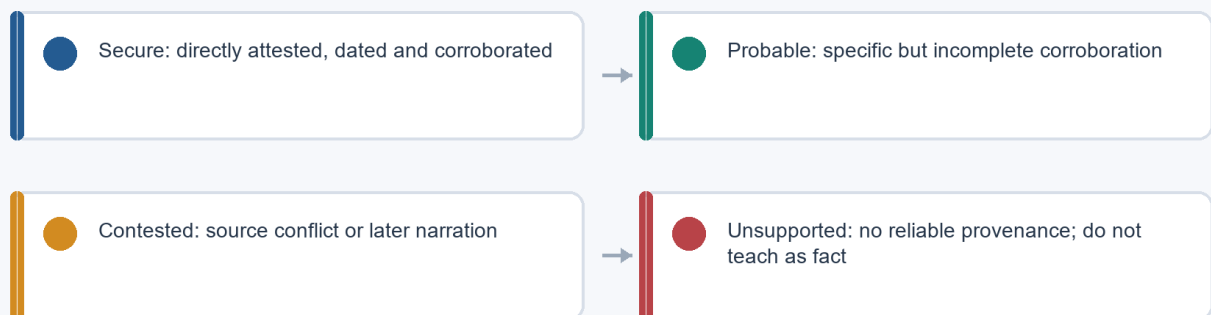


Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 58: *Waqā-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahī*

Visual 58: *Waqā-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahī*. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

Claim-certainty ladder



Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 59: *Claim-certainty ladder*

Visual 59: *Claim-certainty ladder*. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

Modern litigation is not medieval proof

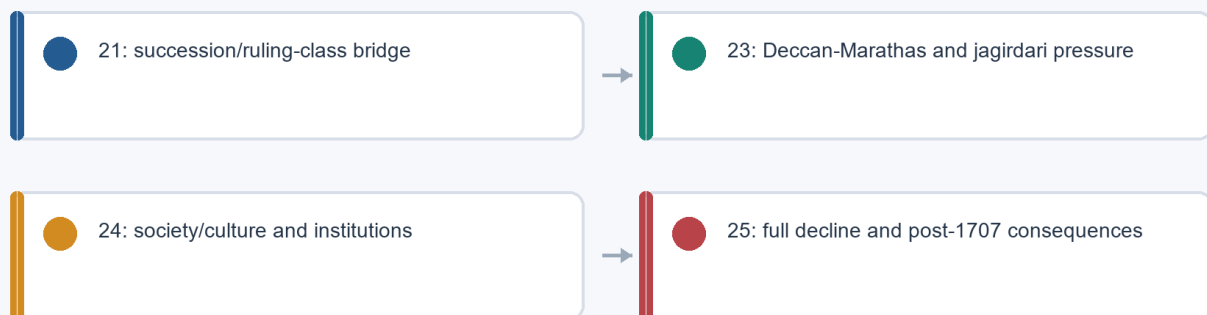


Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 60: Modern litigation is not medieval proof

Visual 60: Modern litigation is not medieval proof. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

Topic boundaries: cross-link without duplication

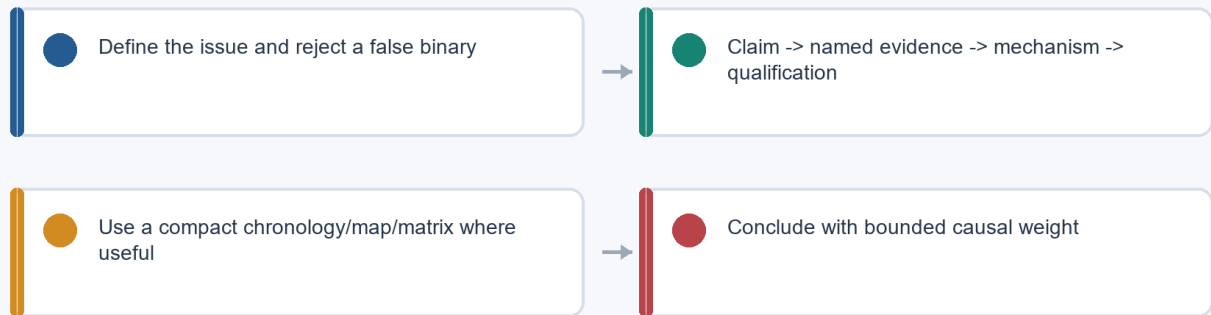


Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 61: Topic boundaries: cross-link without duplication

Visual 61: Topic boundaries: cross-link without duplication. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

Mains answer spine



Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 62: Mains answer spine

Visual 62: Mains answer spine. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

Rapid recall: 60-second exit chart



Original study visual | Evidence-led, schematic and not a substitute for source checking

Visual 63: Rapid recall: 60-second exit chart

Visual 63: Rapid recall: 60-second exit chart. Original topic-specific study visual; schematic maps are explicitly NOT TO SCALE.

PART XV - PYQ AUDIT AND ORIGINAL PRACTICE

Direct PYQ status and routing decision

Local official/OCR CSE 2018-2025 Prelims and GS-I material plus available routing ledgers were searched for direct questions on the owner cluster. **No exact direct verified CSE PYQ owned by this Topic 22 cluster was found.** The one OCR occurrence of “Aurangzeb” is a ruler-identification option, not a question on this topic. Generic Bhakti/Sikh, Maratha/Deccan or art questions are adjacent and are not misrouted. Thus no exact wording, option order or official key is invented. The following 80 items are original practice.

PART XVI - EXAMINER-GRADE MAINS PRACTICE WITH SOLUTIONS

Each model follows directive fidelity, direct thesis, claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification, and a bounded conclusion.

Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Examine Aurangzeb's religious policy through the relationship between orthodoxy and statecraft. Answer in 150 words.

Model solution Aurangzeb's policy cannot be read as either private belief mechanically governing every act or value-free statecraft. Orthodoxy shaped the legal-symbolic idiom: the preference for Hanafi jurisprudence, patronage of the Fatawa-i-Alamgiri and jizyah in 1679 are named evidence. The emperor nevertheless remained a Timurid sovereign using zawabit, office, recruitment and political discretion. Continued Hindu and Rajput/Maratha service shows that state incorporation did not end. The mechanism is therefore differentiated rule: religious preference changed public signals and selected policies, while imperial necessity still shaped timing and implementation. The qualification is crucial: uneven implementation does not erase discrimination or documented coercion. A balanced verdict is that orthodoxy and statecraft were mutually entangled, with political choices giving religious idiom concrete consequences.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 10 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 2 - 15 marks

Question: Assess whether jizyah was more fiscal, religious or political in significance. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution Jizyah, reimposed in 1679, was formally a poll tax and must be separated from land revenue and customs. Its fiscal character is real because collection machinery and officials were involved; however, no uncited empire-wide yield should be asserted. Its religious significance lay in the classical legal idiom of differentiated subject status and in reversal of an Akbar-era position. Its political significance was larger still: a visible signal could alienate sections of Hindu subjects, offer legitimacy to a particular idiom of rule and create local opportunities for harassment. Satish Chandra's stress on uneven collection, corruption and failure to rally Muslims prevents a simple revenue-success story. Conversely, uneven collection is not evidence that the signal had no effect. The best verdict is layered: fiscal in form, religious in status language and political in consequence. It reinforced existing tensions but did not independently explain every revolt or Mughal decline.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 15 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 3 - 15 marks

Question: Discuss Aurangzeb's temple policy without reducing it to either blanket destruction or blanket protection. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution Temple policy requires case-by-case reconstruction. Legal discussion around old places, new construction and repair provides one normative frame; it cannot substitute for evidence of what particular officials did. The 1669 order in chronicle context and the cases of Kashi Vishwanath and Mathura Keshava Rai show that punitive and symbolic action occurred. Marwar/Mewar actions must additionally be placed in occupation and local administrative settings. Motives may combine orthodoxy, rebellion, sovereignty display, complaint and strategy. Equally, farmans or grants to temples, Brahmins and institutions show continuing transactions and protection in particular cases. They qualify a universal-destruction thesis but do not erase destruction. An examiner-grade conclusion classifies the action precisely-demolition, conversion, confiscation, closure, restriction or grant-and rates source certainty. This approach acknowledges real violence and discrimination while refusing sensational lists or unsupported modern allegations.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 15 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 4 - 10 marks

Question: Evaluate the consequences of Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution for Sikh political development. Answer in 150 words.

Model solution Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution in 1675 was consequential because it became a powerful focus of Sikh martyr memory and sharpened the community's relationship to imperial power. Mughal framing in terms of law and order and Sikh traditions, including religious-freedom memory, need not be collapsed into a single uncontested motive. Satish Chandra records the official framing but judges the act unjustified and notes its wider religious repercussions. The named later evidence is Guru Gobind Singh's establishment of the Khalsa in 1699. The analytical link is not mechanical: memory, leadership, organisation, hill politics and later conflicts mediate between 1675 and 1699. Thus the execution was a major accelerant in political-military transformation, not the solitary cause of Khalsa formation or proof that all Sikh-Mughal relations began as purely religious conflict.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 10 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 5 - 15 marks

Question: Analyse Jat and Satnami resistance as evidence of local stress and mobilisation. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution The Mathura-region Jat rising around Gokula and the Satnami revolt at Narnaul in 1672 reveal how local encounters could become armed challenges. In the Jat case, cultivation, zamindari power, revenue pressure, official coercion, routes linking Mathura-Agra-Delhi and community mobilisation must be held together. Religious grievance should be added only where a specific source makes that connection. In the Satnami case, a local confrontation escalated through a sect/community setting and was rapidly suppressed by imperial force. The comparison shows that neither event was a simple class revolution, mere religious disturbance or proof of general collapse. They differed in geography, leadership and social composition. Recurrence under later Jat figures such as Rajaram, and then Churaman after Aurangzeb, helps trace a longer regional process without prematurely creating Bharatpur in 1669. The conclusion: coercive capacity endured, but local legitimacy and extraction could remain unstable.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 15 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 6 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the Marwar succession crisis as a failure of Mughal statecraft. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution Jaswant Singh's 1678 death at Jamrud produced a disputed succession; he had no surviving male heir at the moment, but posthumous claimants made Ajit Singh central. The first analytical error is to say he simply died childless; the second is to equate khalisa with permanent annexation. Crown-revenue control had precedents in disputed succession and alleged debt, as local materials such as Waqa-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahi help illuminate. Yet formal precedent could not neutralise political experience. Searches, occupation, official conduct, favour to Inder Singh and uncertainty about Ajit's custody or settlement converted administrative intervention into an honour-and-watan crisis. Durgadas's role in protecting Ajit's claim gave resistance a durable symbol. Temple actions could intensify the sense of insult, but they do not remove the succession and sovereignty issue. The verdict is statecraft failure: a potentially manageable succession was handled in a manner that exhausted trust and yielded no equivalent gain.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 15 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 7 - 10 marks

Question: Discuss Mewar's role and Prince Akbar's revolt in the Rajput crisis. Answer in 150 words.

Model solution Mewar's intervention reflected kinship with Rajput concerns, fear of Mughal interference in Marwar, territorial-security interests and defence of autonomy; jizyah was a signal but not a sufficient explanation. Aravalli terrain increased the value of local mobility and made occupation costly. Prince Akbar's 1681 revolt created a dynastic alternative with Rathor and Mewar support; Durgadas formed an important link in resistance memory. It failed because coalition and legitimacy were fragile and imperial counter-moves were effective. The forged-letter episode should be labelled source-sensitive rather than repeated as settled fact. The revolt's military failure did not repair the alliance: resistance and distrust survived. It is therefore best read as a failed immediate challenge that exposed a deeper prestige and guarantee problem.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 10 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 8 - 20 marks

Question: Assess the political cost of the Rajput rupture to the Mughal Empire. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution The breach with Marwar and Mewar was politically more damaging than its later narrow troop figures suggest. Earlier Mughal-Rajput partnership supplied commanders, local knowledge and a language of reciprocal honour. Aurangzeb initially used Jai Singh and Jaswant Singh, making the later rupture a loss of confidence within a living alliance rather than a foreordained religious war. The Marwar succession handling, jizyah in 1679 and contested temple/occupation actions together made imperial guarantees appear less reliable. Chandra's judgement that the policy was clumsy and blundering rests on this absence of compensating advantage. Continued Hada and Kachhwaha service is a necessary qualification: there was no universal Rajput secession. Nor did the empire collapse in 1681. Yet differentiated service cannot remove the political mechanism: distrust raises bargaining and enforcement costs, while wider Deccan commitments increase the value of dependable allies. The best verdict is a serious legitimacy loss that compounded, but did not replace, fiscal-military pressures and the Deccan war.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 20 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 9 - 20 marks

Question: Compare Akbar's and Aurangzeb's approaches to religious policy and elite bargain. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution Akbar's sulh-i-kul provided an inclusive imperial idiom and helped turn Rajput partnership into a durable state practice. It did not make the Mughal state a modern secular democracy, nor did it eliminate hierarchy and force. Aurangzeb's policy placed greater public stress on Hanafi legal idiom, supported the Fatawa-i-Alamgiri, reimposed jizyah and authorised or permitted important temple actions in particular contexts. These measures altered the fiscal-symbolic environment and damaged trust, especially when joined to the Marwar crisis. Yet Aurangzeb also retained sovereign discretion, zawabit and composite recruitment; continued Hindu service means the contrast cannot be rendered as total inclusion versus total exclusion. The proper comparative axes are legal idiom, fiscal differentiation, case-specific temple policy, office/recruitment and credibility of alliance. The conclusion is not a tolerance-intolerance morality play: Akbar's bargain invested more in a shared public language, whereas Aurangzeb's choices made political incorporation coexist with sharper differentiation and more fragile legitimacy.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 20 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Mains 10 - 20 marks

Question: Using source criticism, evaluate religious policy as a factor in Mughal weakening. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution Religious policy contributed to weakening by changing legitimacy signals, alienating sections of subjects and aggravating particular local conflicts; it is not a monocausal explanation. Jizyah in 1679, the documented Kashi/Mathura sequence, Guru Tegh Bahadur's execution and Marwar-Mewar mistrust are named evidence for concrete political consequences. But their reach must be assessed through source type. Court chronicles such as Maasir-i-Alamgiri give official chronology and ideology; Waqa-i-Ajmer and Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahi add local succession and administrative context; farmans and inscriptions prove particular grants or actions rather than an empire-wide rule; Sikh and Rajput traditions preserve memory but require provenance analysis. Continued service by many Hindu elites qualifies universal exclusion. Deccan war, elite/jagirdari pressures and regional assertion qualify a one-cause decline story. Thus historical disagreement should be resolved by specificity and corroboration, not false balance. Aurangzeb was both constrained by circumstances and a maker of circumstances: his choices worsened a multi-causal imperial problem.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses named evidence rather than a slogan, explains a mechanism, and keeps a source/causal qualification visible. For 20 marks, reproduce the thesis, two to six precise evidence units as appropriate, and the final bounded verdict rather than adding an unverified statistic.

Final solved-answer self-audit

Before reproducing any model answer, test whether it actually answers the directive. A response on jizyah should distinguish poll tax from land revenue, name 1679, analyse fiscal form and religious-political signal, and avoid an invented yield. A temple-policy response should classify the action, name the source type and refuse both a universal-destruction assertion and a grant-as-alibi assertion. A Rajput response should distinguish watan, khalisa and succession from a simple religious explanation, while still acknowledging that jizyah and temple action could deepen distrust. A Sikh answer should separate immediate framing from long-term martyr memory and the 1699 Khalsa. Finally, an empire-wide verdict must state why religious policy was consequential without treating it as a replacement for the Deccan war, elite pressure and regional assertion. If the answer cannot state one limitation that changes its scale, it is probably reciting rather than analysing.

Solved-practice completion check: Every answer should end with a bounded verdict, not a slogan: a dated case can support a wider qualified inference, but it cannot bear a claim about every locality, subject or motive.